

to the game-world, and becomes one with it, the game designer can lead the player on a fantastic roller-coaster ride. To establish suspension of disbelief, the game-world has to be believable. For example, flying aliens in a World War 2 game make no sense. If everything fits, suspension of disbelief is not hard to achieve.

Another aspect to be considered is player involvement. The world and the environment created should be responsive, and the player should have a lot of freedom to do things inside it. The more involved the player is in flying, shooting, running, giving orders, etc, the more fun he has. Finally, if it's not fun, it's not worth it.

Because players need to mentally surrender to the game, there is, naturally, a tendency to call them juvenile. However, as psychologists point out, most have a rather high IQ. Dr Rao says, "Some high-IQ people are not successful in life.

Only the average person has the tenacity to go on and succeed. High-IQ people get bored very easily. They want something new, something different, and this desire is exploited by computer games." This is why high-IQ people tend to fall for addiction faster than those with an average IQ.

Endgame

All the gamers spoken to agreed that it is unethical to play pirated games. They are aware of the rights of intellectual property, but they say they

have no choice. Vishal and Varun reckon that games are too expensive to buy consistently. Both, however, admit to having spent more than a lakh on their PCs.

"I like to think of games as an art form for this generation" says Samrat. As for addiction, "It's your involvement that makes a game addictive," he says. Maybe it's an art form, maybe it's an addiction, but in the United States, there are people who regularly spend entire nights and weekends 'living' and 'working' in virtual lands such as *EverQuest*. *EverQuest* is a virtual world in which people work for a living just as in the real world—and they even trade virtual goods for real money on real-life auction sites such as eBay.

Meanwhile, the numbers of gamers increase, and in a world becoming increasingly devoid of empty, open spaces and free movement, we have begun to turn towards virtual worlds, where the colours are rich, the movement is free, and you can run, race or kill at your own pace. The bottomline is that there is no limit to what you can do in a game, as long as you play by its rules. Maybe that is what it is: dreams come true inside the mind of a gamer! ☒

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Rahul Rohira feels that reality is distinct from a game

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